

THE BRIDGE OF LIFE

He had an iron **grip**, which pulled me through. My husband followed, after seeing me safe at the other end. He was **escorted** too. We reached the second floor of the unfinished house, safe and sound. I was **trembling** with the sudden rush of **adrenaline**. The boys took us to their sleeping quarters. All the while it kept pouring. "Stop it," I wanted to yell out to the skies.

A huge **tarpaulin** was spread out on the floor and I was given the spot nearest to the window to sleep. It was cold. The boys cooked - rice on their makeshift chulha and offered us some. But we were not hungry; the **anxiety** had proved to be too much. We were surrounded by 12 young men. We did not know them, but we felt **secure**. They went to so much trouble to save our lives. And Shen made sure we got some sleep. They reminded me of my two sons who were in the US.

The water started **receding** the next day, the morning of 3 December. Our young friend escorted me back to our house so I could use the washroom. I walked back the same way, gingerly holding on to Mansoor's hand.

But this time, I was not so scared. Water **swirled** around the house in circles. The ground floor was submerged. The compound wall at the back had fallen. The water was forcing its way in from all directions. By noon we were very hungry. The boys offered us a bowl of hot rice. We had very little drinking water left- half a bottle to be **exact**.

Around 2 p.m. news came in that more water was likely to be released from the **reservoir**. This would be the death of us.

(To be continued...)